

# The Masters and Their Methods

By Anthony Hudson

What do Fabio Capello, Jose Mourinho, Alex Ferguson and Arsene Wenger all have in common? On the surface, they hold about 93 trophies between them, including Premier League titles, Serie A titles, Champions League, UEFA Cup, FA Cup and many others. If that isn't enough to capture your interest, how about if I take a look at each of these masters of the coaching world, to see how their experiences can benefit other coaches?

I am aware that this article is biased. I am looking at areas and places that I think can be used in order to help you become a better coach. This article is not meant to describe their careers.

## Fabio Capello

Fabio Capello has a reputation as "the greatest manager in the world." He demands a consistent discipline and insists on respect and hard work from his players. As a result, his teams have a habit of winning games. These traits may not seem so glamorous to some of today's coaching fraternity, but the fact of the matter is they translate to nothing more than wanting to win.

Top Italian goalkeeper Iker Casillas recalled Capello as "having a lot of intensity and is on top of everybody – all the time." He demands that every training session be like a match – same tension, same intensity, same build-up, same concentration. The man is a winner, and his record definitely speaks for itself. Capello put it in simple terms as manager of Roma: "I don't have a minimum target for next season. I have only one objective: to win it all!"

There has been much written about Capello and discipline. It seems anything that has the potential to become a distraction to winning is promptly removed. From mobile phones to club directors, they are not welcome in and around the preparations of the team. They are, as Capello states, "distractions." He demands that his players respect others wherever they go, be it hotel staff or waiters in a restaurant.

"I do not accept lack of respect!" he says. "Would you like it if someone spoke to your father or brother badly? You must never forget – you must respect others." He also mentioned that "fans liked it when I cracked the whip. They see that I have a plan."

When Capello is interviewed, he often can be heard talking about the "group" and the "spirit of the group." This constant seems to come from his passion and his demands for good, strong character. Discipline and having a clear, strong set of team rules are "necessary to create a group," he says. "Functioning this way always has given results."

This man of character, so sure of himself and his ability, now leads the England National team into the 2010 World Cup. This is a long way from his days at AC Milan. Having just finished his playing career and learning to become a coach, he took a year off from soccer. He used this time to study business, learning from the corporate world under the guidance of club President Silvio Berlusconi, who is now Italy's Prime Minister. It's been said that he approached that year with real "spirit and enthusiasm" – something I would imagine most coaches would find very difficult to do, especially being pulled away from soccer for so long and thrown into unknown territories. Seeking education from these outside sources is very rare in the game, but I can't help but believe that they have made him a better coach, manager and person.

## Coaching Lessons from Fabio Capello

- Demand high standards – every day from everyone
- Make sure training is exactly like the game.
  - o Same intensity
  - o Same build-up
  - o Same tension
  - o Same concentration
- Make sure your players show respect to and for others.
- Discipline – Find your set of rules and stick to them.
  - o "Rules are necessary to create the group." – Capello
- Seek outside learning – business, language, communications, etc.

## Jose Mourinho

"We have top players, and – I'm sorry I'm a bit arrogant – we have a top manager. I am the European champion. I think I am special."

And special he is!

"As entertaining as the Premier League is, the majority of the managers don't do much in terms of inspiring the public. Post-game interviews and press conferences filled with clichés and predictability seem to be the norm. When Jose Mourinho came along and uttered the above words, you knew he was different. Almost as if an actor on stage, he leaves everyone, including his players, with something to talk about. His comments are thought-provoking and at times a whole lot more! He uses his pre- and post-match words to speak not just to the people with the microphones, but also his players, other managers in the league and football's governing bodies all over. What he displays 100 percent of the time is a complete and utter knowing and confidence in his own ability as a coach and as a manager. He is not afraid to speak his mind and can back it up

with performance and results.

Deco once said that "there are many coaches with the same ability as Mourinho, but no one works as hard as him." As coaches, what does that do for you? How can that affect you? Here's a man who, after an unfulfilled playing career, declared out loud that he would strive to become the "best coach in the world." If he's not there yet, he's on his way and getting close. Former coaches of Barcelona, Bobby Robson and Louis Van Gaal – whom Mourinho assisted – both commented on how Mourinho's work was first class. His scouting and match reports were the best "bar none," detailing the strengths and weaknesses of both teams, characteristics of each player, how he would play against them and on and on. He "listened, learned, looked, remembered. He was bright, alert and intelligent," Robson said.

Hard work is definitely at the heart of what this great coach is all about. A trait that is thrown around so much today is "attention to detail." Everyone says it – commentators, coaches, assistant coaches and general managers. I met a former colleague of Mourinho's and asked what was the one thing Mourinho taught him. He said without hesitation, "He was the champion of details."

So what are the details? I would say the characteristics Bobby Robson talked about certainly lead to this quality of paying attention to detail. The details can be seen in how he prepares for games, handing personalized (well-edited) DVDs to his players before games, showing the opposing players they'll be marking, the type of runs they make, their strengths and weaknesses and more. His training methods, his use of the training field, of pitch sizes, amount of players, how he incorporates his fitness coach, his communication with his owners, the press – everything is meticulous and with a purpose. The amount of detail he puts into scouting and preparing for games. The way he transmits his message to his players so they walk into games knowing they are already a step ahead. "He has a knack of transmitting his amazing confidence," said Frank Lampard. "He drums it in every day that you're the best."

As Mourinho says of himself: "I have complete confidence in myself. I am not afraid of the future. I know I can make a difference." Say no more!

## Coaching Lessons from Mourinho

- Have confidence in your ability – 100 percent of the time.
- Be unpredictable – learn to act (keep people on their toes).
- Take care of the details – prepare your team well.
- "Be bright. Be alert. Be intelligent. Be ambitious. Be confident."
- Work hard.

- o “There are many coaches with the same ability, but NO ONE works as hard as him.” – Deco.

## Alex Ferguson

Alex Ferguson may go down as one of the most successful British managers of all time. He has produced countless world-class teams and soccer players, many of whom are turning into top managers themselves. To put it in perspective, when Alex Ferguson took over at Manchester United, one of the biggest teams in the world, the Berlin Wall was still standing and Nelson Mandela was still in prison. I once asked a top English manager for advice on being a coach. He said, “Whatever you do, make sure you stay in the game!” No one has done it better than Fergie. Longevity, stamina, mental toughness and character in such a high-pressured industry are traits displayed in ways that few can identify with or match.

What impresses me as I watch Ferguson work with such a steely and tough approach, has been his willingness to share some of his insecurities, his moments when he’s had to dig real deep; he hasn’t been afraid to talk about it. No false strength, as the large majority seems to show off. He tells his story exactly how it is with brutal honesty. He has spoken about very low times in his career, when he doubted himself, felt lonely, isolated and insecure. “I went home to bed and put the pillow over my head. A sense of guilt engulfed me...was I doing something wrong?...I felt really uncomfortable with my position.” Who would have thought, seeing him work and watching his amazing career unfold, that he could go through this? He speaks about the pressures of the job, dealing with bad results, “feeling isolated, betrayed, helpless and even creating demons in my head.” It adds to an even greater lesson in staying in the game...and in life! You will go through tough times, but you have to dig deep and stay in the game.

Ferguson seems to have developed these tough qualities at a young age growing up in Scotland. He seems to be proud of his upbringing and his family’s mining background. He has deep affection for Govan, the district where he grew up in southwest Glasgow. He named one of his racehorses for a boat his father helped build in the shipyards. His father was a major influence on him, always bringing him down to earth, teaching him great values. He was “assiduous about timekeeping...I am always early – it’s a great discipline,” he recounted. He also looked up to and learned from other great managers. Bill Shankly was “a great inspiration for me. I used to have cassette tapes of his interviews.” His affection for Jock Stein and the way he speaks of him can’t help but bring a smile to one’s face. “For any young manager – Jock Stein was a one-man university...when Jock came into a room he dominated it. He knew everybody’s first name and that’s a wonderful asset to have. It makes people feel important.”

He learned from those before him and carries such strong principles with him into management. Other aspects of Ferguson that really stand out are his character, his approach and his personality. Ferguson is in no way afraid to speak his mind. He talks about mental toughness in interviews and for me is a perfect example of it.

“Sheer hard work was a huge factor in bringing success, but I am sure that sticking to my beliefs was equally important.” As a young manager at East Stirlingshire, his team trailed 2-0 during the second half and a panicked and angry team owner of the team came down to the dugout and asked what he was going to do. Fergie responded, “I’m going to throw you out of this dugout if you don’t move now!” It’s a lot easier for him to be able to do that now, but as a younger and less accomplished manager, I don’t think it was as easy. What a great lesson to be learned: Stick to your guns, believe in what you’re doing and not being afraid to tell others what needs to be said....and you can figure out the best way to get your message across!

He talks about his first day at Manchester United, how he was nervous and how he tackled the massive problem of drinking among the Manchester United players. He changed the “48-hour drinking rule” to make it an offense if players were caught drinking anytime. He stated that it was difficult for his new players to observe, but he knew his words were “a declaration (of his) attitude.” What strength of character – coming into one of the biggest clubs in the world and “declaring your attitude.”

In looking at his personality in interviews, on the training pitch and on the sideline, much can be learned. Label it what you will – the fact of the matter is he gets people to do what he wants them to do and he gets the job done. “I use rhetorical questions, leaving others no choice but to endorse my suggestions,” says Fergie. “Your personality has to force things because sometimes you cannot wait.”

Finally, Ferguson states, “I had that burning desire to change the world!” How important is that?

### Coaching Lessons from Ferguson

- Stay in the game – be mentally tough.
- Be open and honest.
- Have discipline.
  - o Time management – “I am always early.”
- Learn from others. Seek out the best and learn from them.
  - o Be creative – “I used to listen to cassette tapes of Shankly.”
- Know everybody’s first name.
  - o “Jock Stein knew everybody’s first name and that’s a wonderful asset to have.”
- Even the best of the best have fears and insecurities. It’s what you do with them that sets you apart from others.
- You’re the coach – Stick to what you believe in regardless of what others think. (Fergie did it at the biggest club in the world!)
- Be ambitious – “Want to change the world.”

## Arsene Wenger

“Discipline, a way with words, a willingness to work hard, a respect and a confidence in others may come across as naïve, but has paid dividends over time.” – Arsene Wenger

Coaches and managers at the highest level have been so stereotypical over the years. Ranting, raving, screaming, shouting, pacing and barking on the touchline all seem to be “what coaches do.” This image or approach is even more prevalent in lower leagues and, unfortunately, just as bad with young kids. Arsene

Wenger entered the Premier League looking and acting more like a schoolteacher than a top-level manager. His nickname at Arsenal was “Windows” because of his big, studious glasses. However, over time he has shown that he has a great ability to analyze games and situations while everyone around him seems to panic. He is able to stay calm. He is able to detach himself from results, games, arguments, even the outside world in order to analyze more clearly. He doesn’t allow himself to be distracted by little things. His approach and personality is so refreshing – he is different from the rest, and there’s so much to be learned.

By all accounts it is evident that he is absolutely obsessed with the game of football. He has said that he thinks of the game 90 percent of his waking hours, that a “night without a game of football on TV leaves me disillusioned.” He spends hours and hours studying video footage of his team, opponents and players, in his own little world. He lives for, and is obsessed by, football.

This obsession colors every area of the game. He studies everything from diet and medicine to athletics and is fascinated with isometrics. His attention to everything surrounding the game, the preparation and the recovery of the player, is immense.

Wenger has strong views on diet – both his players’ and his own. He apparently prepares the same way the players do, stating “how can I ask them to fight for me if I cannot stand shoulder to shoulder with them?” He has educated many by introducing his beliefs on the way players should eat and live. He uses dietary analysis for all new players, puts together player diet profiles and has dieticians speak to the players and their wives. Meal times are set with fine attention relating to the human body. Single players have to eat at the training ground, and he follows through with very strict rules on the players’ weight and body mass, even punishing by sending players to train with the reserves until they get themselves to the correct body weight. Recuperation, diet and treatment seem to be his Holy Grail, with everything aimed at the players’ well-being.

The preparation and attention to his players’ well-being is something not too common in the game and demonstrates his faith in and respect for his players. His players – whom he states are “the soul of the team” – come first. So many coaches and managers today seem to detest players. Wenger treats his players as adults. He asks them how they feel, values their opinions and views. “I trust people,” says Wenger. “I don’t see danger coming around every corner. I have a positive image of human beings.”

### Coaching Lessons from Wenger

- Be calm. Try to become a better observer. Analyze.
  - o “Don’t get distracted by the little things.”
- Become obsessed. Study the game.
- Seek education – medicine, diet, other sports and isometrics.
- Learn about the players’ diets.
- Be a role model. Don’t ask something from your players you are not prepared to do yourself.